

日本語

Japanese phrasebook

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Changes made for Kana: the pictures, the links and the section “Learning more” left out; laid out as a PDF. This PDF is under CC BY-SA 4.0 too: you may share and adapt it, crediting Wikivoyage, under the same licence.

Japanese phrasebook

Japanese (日本語 *nihongo*) is spoken in Japan, and essentially nowhere else other than areas of Micronesia, Brazil, Peru, the United States and Taiwan where there is a long-established Japanese diaspora, with sizeable Japanese-speaking expatriate communities in South Korea, China and Singapore. Japanese may be distantly related to Korean, but is entirely unrelated to Chinese, though it uses a large amount of imported Chinese vocabulary. The written form uses a combination of Katakana, Hiragana and Kanji characters which were all derived from Chinese characters.

The **Japanese** language has several distinct dialects. Standard Japanese (*hyōjungo* 標準語), which is based on the Tokyo dialect, is taught in schools and understood by all people throughout the country. The slang-heavy dialect of the Kansai region is particularly famous in Japanese pop culture, while the northern Tohoku region and southern Kyushu are famous for their impenetrable dialects. On the southern islands of Okinawa, many of the closely related **Ryukyuan** languages are spoken, mostly by the elderly, while many locals speak Okinawan Japanese, a dialect that borrows much vocabulary from Ryukyuan languages. In northern Hokkaido, a rare few still speak **Ainu**.

Pronunciation guide

Japanese is not a tonal language like Chinese or Thai. The vowels are pronounced virtually identical to the "Italian way" and there are very few consonants that do not exist in English. All syllables are to be pronounced equal in length. Long vowels take the length of two syllables. Combinations like *kya* are treated like one syllable and are the only occurrence of glides (semivowels), all other syllables are to be pronounced rather separately.

Also avoid placing too much emphasis on particular words or syllables. Although Japanese does have a form of stress and intonation, it is significantly flatter than English. Word stress is much more subtle and neglecting it at this point should not interfere with meaning. Trying to keep your intonation flat will make your attempts to speak Japanese more comprehensible to local listeners. When asking questions, you can raise the tone at the end, as in English.

Vowels

Japanese has only five basic vowels, but the distinction between short and long vowels is important. For example, 少女 (*shōjo*, with a long first vowel) means "teenage girl", while 処女 (*shojo*, with a short first vowel) means "virgin woman". Even when it comes to proper nouns, you will not be understood if you do not distinguish the long and short vowels correctly. The sounds below are first given in romanized Japanese, then hiragana and finally katakana.

The **short vowels** are:

a, あ, ア

like 'a' in "palm"

i, い, イ

like 'i' in "marine"

u, う, ウ

like 'oo' in "hoop", but short (said without rounded lips)

e, え, エ

like 'e' in "set"

o, お, オ

like 'o' in "rope", but less round

Note that "u" is often weak at the end of syllables. In particular, the common endings *desu* and *masu* are usually pronounced as *des* and *mas* respectively. Also, the kana "do" and "to" are sometimes pronounced with a weak "o".

The **long vowels** are generally the same sound as the short vowels, only held approximately 60% longer. The long vowels, marked with a macron (̄) or by two adjacent vowels, are:

ā, ああ, アー

like 'a' in "father"

ī or ī, いい, イー

like 'ee' in "cheese"

ū, うう, ウー

like 'oo' in "hoop"

ei or ē, えい, ええ, エー

like the 'ay' in "pay"

ō, おお, おう, オー

stretch out the 'o' in "soap"

All descriptions above are approximations, it's best to practice with a native speaker.

Consonants

Note on vocalization

Japanese words starting with h/k/s/t are often vocalized on later positions in compounds. Place name examples:

- Hashi (橋, bridge) > -bashi
- Kawa (川, river) > -gawa
- Saka (坂, slope) > -zaka
- Tōri (通り, street) > -dōri

With the solitary exception of "n" (ん・ン), consonants in Japanese are always followed by a vowel to form a syllable. Consonants and vowels are not freely combinable as in English, see table on the right for all possible syllables and note irregularities like し *shi* or ふ *fu*. Certain syllables can be marked with diacritics, which alters the pronunciation of the consonant part. The list below first gives the consonant part of the syllable in romanized Japanese, then the Japanese syllables that the sound occurs in first in Hiragana, then Katakana.

k in かきくけこ・カキクケコ (ka ki ku ke ko)

like 'k' in "king"

g in がぎぐげご・ガギグゲゴ (ga gi gu ge go)

like 'g' in "go"

s in さすせそ・サスセソ (sa su se so)

like 's' in "sit"

z in ざずぜぞ・ザズゼゾ・づ・ヅ (za zu ze zo) (dzu) (zu)

like 'z' in "haze"

t in たてと・タテト (ta te to)

like 't' in "top"

d in だでど・ダデド (da de do)

like 'd' in "dog"

n in なにぬねの・ナニヌネノ (na ni nu ne no)

like 'n' in "nice"

h in はひへほ・ハヒヘホ (ha/wa hi fu/hu he/e ho)

like 'h' in "help"

p in ぱぴぷぺぽ・パピプペポ (pa pi pu pe po)

like 'p' in "pig"

b in ばびぶべぼ・バビブベボ (ba bi bu be bo)

like 'b' in "bed"

m in まみむめも・マミムメモ (**ma mi mu me mo**)

like 'm' in "mother"

y in やゆよ・ヤユヨ (**ya yu yo**)

like 'y' in "yard"

r in らりるれろ・ラリルレロ (**ra ri ru re ro**)

no equivalent in English, a sound between 'l', 'r' and 'd', but close to a very soft 'r'

w in わを・ワヲ (**wa wo/o**)

like 'w' in "wall"

sh in し・シ (**shi**)

like 'sh' in "sheep"

j in じ・ジ・ぢ・ヂ (**ji**)

like 'j' in "jar"

ch in ち・チ (**chi**)

like 'ch' in "touch"

ts in つ・ツ (**tsu**)

like 'ts' in "hot soup"

f in ふ・フ (**fu/hu**)

no equivalent in English, somewhere between 'h' and 'f', but you will be understood if you pronounce it either way

n, ん, ン (-n)

short 'n', slides towards 'm' in some cases

Small symbols

The symbols つ・ツ and やゆよ・ヤユヨ, as well as あいうえお・アイウエオ can be written in a smaller size. In the latter group, this is almost always seen only in katakana, as it is only used for loan words. The small つ・ツ indicates a glottal stop, as listed below, while for the rest of the symbols, indicates that they are to be pronounced as part of the same syllable of the preceding symbol. For instance, in the loan word フォーク (*fōku*), from English "fork", note the smaller size of the 才, which is why it is *not* pronounced *fuōku*. To highlight the importance of this distinction, びょういん (*byōin*, with the small よ) means hospital, and びょういん (*biyōin*, with the big よ pronounced as a separate syllable from the び) means beauty salon.

っ・っ (small tsu)

glottal stop; the following consonant is prepared, held and stopped for

the duration of one syllable. For example, にっぽん *nippon* is pronounced "nip-(pause)-pon". (Note that the double consonants *nn*, *mm*, which are not written with っ, do not have this pause.)

Examples

- *kon'nichiwa* → *kon-nee-chee-wa* (**not** *kounneeCHEEua*)
- *sumimasen* → *soo-mee-mah-sen* (**not** *sue my maysen*)
- *onagai shimasu* → *oh-neh-gigh shee-mahss* (**not** *ounneeGAY SHYmessu*)

Grammar

Japanese sentence structure is very similar to that of Korean, so speakers of Korean will find many aspects of Japanese grammar familiar, and vice versa.

Unlike English, which uses the *subject-verb-object* syntax, Japanese syntax is *subject-object-verb*. Japanese uses postpositions instead of prepositions (*Japan in* and not *in Japan*). However, unlike many European languages, it has no gender, declensions or plurals. Nouns never decline while adjectives follow a generally standard conjugation pattern. However, verbs have extensive conjugation patterns and many Japanese lessons for foreign language learners are about getting these conjugations right. Verbs and adjectives also conjugate by politeness level, though, and in a rather peculiar way.

Japanese is an agglutinative language, meaning several morphemes which have purely grammatical functions are glued to the end of a word stem to express the grammatical function. The more the intended meaning differs from the basic form of the word, the more morphemes are glued together.

Japanese verb and adjective conjugation				
stem 見る <i>miru</i> 見 <i>m</i> 見 <i>m</i> い	basic form 見る <i>miru</i> , "to see"	polite basic form 見ます <i>mimasu</i> , "to see" (pol.)	negative form 見ない <i>minai</i> , "to not see"	pol. neg. form 見ません <i>mimasen</i> , "to not see" (pol.)
	past tense 見た <i>mita</i> , "seen"	pol. past tense 見ました <i>mimashita</i> , "seen" (pol.)	neg. past tense 見なかった <i>minakatta</i> , "not seen"	pol. neg. past tense 見ませんでした <i>mimasendeshita</i> , "not seen" (pol.)

	possibility y 見える <i>mieru</i> , "can see"	pol. possibility 見えます <i>miemasu</i> , "can see" (pol.)	neg. possibility 見えない <i>mienai</i> , "can not see"	pol. negative form 見えません <i>miemasen</i> , "can not see" (pol.)
stem 赤 <i>aka</i>	adjective 赤い <i>akai</i> , "red"	negative form 赤くない <i>akakunai</i> , "not red"	neg. past tense 赤くなかった <i>akakunakatta</i> , "was not red"	

Forming sentences

Particle pronunciation

The hiragana syllables は **ha**, へ **he** and を **wo** are pronounced as **wa**, **e** and **o** respectively when used as a particle.

Japanese grammar generally employs a subject-object-verb order, but is very modular and flexible since the grammatical meaning of a word is expressed by the morphemes glued to its end and special marker particles. The two most important particles are the topic marker は *wa* and the object marker を *o*.

I saw the movie.

私は映画を見ました。

Watashi-wa eiga-o mimashita.

I-[topic] movie-[object] seen.

It becomes a little more complicated if both objects and subjects are mixed within a sentence and the subject marker が *ga* is thrown in.

I discovered that she likes tea.

私は彼女がお茶を好きな事が分かった。

Watashi-wa kanojo-ga ocha-o sukinakoto-ga wakatta.

I-[topic] she-[subj.] tea-[obj.] like-[subj.] understood.

Students of the language can spend years wrapping their heads around the difference between the *topic* of a sentence (marked by は *wa*) and the *subject* of a sentence (marked by が *ga*). However, as a beginner, you can fairly safely always use は *wa* to mark the person doing the action and get your message across.

Some other useful particles are:

の **no**

possessive marker

The mother's child

母の子

haha no ko

で **de**, に **ni**

indicating places and times

in Tokyo

東京で

Tōkyō-de

at 2 o'clock

2時に

niji-ni

から **kara**, へ **e**, まで **made**

from, towards, to

From here...

ここから...

koko kara...

towards Osaka

大阪へ

Ōsaka-e

to Nara.

奈良まで

Nara-made.

と **to**, か **ka**

and, or

This and that.

これとそれ

kore to sore

This or that.

これかそれ

kore ka sore

か? **ka?**

question forming particle

Are you going to Tokyo?

東京に行きますか?

Tōkyō ni ikimasu ka?

The verb "to be"

Japanese does not have an exact equivalent to the English verb "to be".
Instead, the easiest way to form "**A equals B**" type expressions like "I

am ..." or "This is ..." is the pattern **A wa, B desu**.

私は、山田です。 *Watashi wa, Yamada desu* ("I [am] Yamada.")

これは、りんごです。 *Kore wa, ringo desu* ("This [is] apple.")

それは、赤いです。 *Sore wa, akai desu* ("That [is] red.")

The word です *desu* here is *not* a verb, it's a polite copula (linking word), which can be omitted in colloquial speech or replaced with other copulas including でした *deshita* (polite past), でしょう *deshō* (polite suggestion) or だ *da* (plain). The topic indicated by は *wa* is also optional and is often implied by context:

あなたはだれですか? *Anata wa dare desu ka?* ("Who [are] you?")

山田です。 *Yamada desu*. ("I am] Yamada.")

これは何ですか? *Kore wa nan desu ka?* ("What [is] this?")

りんごです。 *Ringo desu*. ("[This is] an apple.")

それは何色ですか? *Sore wa nani-iro desu ka?* ("What color [is] that?")

赤いです。 *Akai desu*. ("[That is] red.")

The two verbs いる *iru* > *imasu* and ある *aru* > *arimasu* express the **physical presence** of a person or animal in the former case, or an object in the latter case. To say "**A is located in B**", use the pattern **A ga B ni imasu/arimasu** :

山田さんがここにいます。 *Yamada-san ga koko ni imasu*. ("Mr. Yamada is [physically located] here.")

本が棚にありますか? *Hon ga tana ni arimasu ka?* ("Is there a book on the shelf?")

はい、あります。 *Hai, arimasu*. ("Yes, [the book] is [on the shelf].")

Addressing others

Me, myself and I

As long as you're not 100% sure what you're doing you should always refer to yourself as 私 *watashi* and address others by their last name + さん *san*. If you feel adventurous, here are a number of ways to address people.

I

私 *watashi, watakushi*

the most common polite form for "I", lit. "private"

あたし *atashi*

informal feminine version of *watashi*

うち *uchi*

Western dialect form of *watashi*, lit "(my) house", usually used to refer to one's family or home

僕 *boku*

boyish and more informal, used only by males

俺 *ore*

male speak (rude)

you

あなた *anata*

most common form for "you", not too direct

あんた *anta*

more direct, tends to be insulting

君 *kimi*

more direct, mostly by the older person or from a man to a woman

お前 *omae*

very direct and informal, used only by males

てめえ *temē*

very rude, used only by males

More a cultural than a grammatical problem is the problem of addressing somebody. Even though there exist a multitude of words with the meaning "you", it is generally avoided to address somebody directly. The closest equivalent to "you" is あなた *anata*, but it's only used among close friends, to address people of lower status than you, or by women to address their male lovers. It is usually preferred to address somebody by family name, title or status, applying appropriate honorifics.

Note that in Japan, it is generally rude to address people by first name, and last names are almost always used instead. The exception to this rule are children of elementary school age or younger, and friends you are very close to. When names are written in Japanese, they always follow the Eastern name order (like Chinese and Korean names), with the last name always written before the first name, which is contrary to common practice in English-speaking countries. This means that

someone known as Taro Yamada in English will have his name written as 山田太郎 (*yamada tarō*) in Japanese.

さん -*san*

The most basic honorific, about equivalent to Mr. or Ms. (no distinction between the two in Japanese). 山田さん *Yamada-san*: Mister Yamada

様 -*sama*

Politer than *-san*, used to address people ranking higher on the social ladder, such as your supervisor or boss, or even deities. It is also used by shop assistants to address customers.

ちゃん -*chan*

Used to address children of elementary school age or younger and (usually female) close friends.

君 -*kun*

Used to address boys of elementary school age or younger and male close friends.

先生 *sensei*

Used to address teachers, medical doctors and dentists. The person's surname can be appended at the beginning if necessary for disambiguation.

お客様 *okyaku-sama*

"Honored Mr/Ms customer", used by hotel or shop employees to address you.

店長さん *tenchō-san*

The way to address the manager of a shop, though not the other employees.

お兄さん *onīsan*, お姉さん *onēsan*

Literally "big brother" and "big sister" respectively, is used to address young people who you're having a hard time finding a better honorific for.

お爺さん *ojisan*, お婆さん *obāsan*

"Grandpa" and "grandma", very popular to address old people. Cuter when used with *-chan*.

そちら *sochira*

Means something like "on your side" and is used when absolutely no better honorific can be found.

There are also several different words for "I", with 私 *watashi* being the most commonly used. Grammatically it's often unnecessary to use the words "you" or "I" as the intended meaning is obvious from context, so

they should generally be avoided. Sometimes people will also call themselves by their own name. When doing so they must not add any additional honorifics though; one only does this when addressing others.

There's no specific form for "we" or the plural "you". To address groups of people you add the plural particle *たち* *-tachi* to somebody within the group or the group designator.

私たち *watashi-tachi*

lit. "the group around myself", meaning "we"

我々 *ware-ware*

a less formal way of saying "we"

あなたたち *anata-tachi*

"the group around you", plural "you"

子供たち *kodomo-tachi*

"a group of children", meaning "the children"

山田さんたち *Yamada-san-tachi*

"the group around Yamada-san", everybody you'd associate with Mr. Yamada, based on context

Japanese traditionally lacked third person pronouns, and while *彼* (*kare*) and *彼女* (*kanojo*) were repurposed during the Meiji era as "he" and "she" respectively for translating European texts, they sound awfully stilted if you use them when talking to people. Stick to using last name + honorific instead. If you do not know the person's name, you can say *この人* (*ko no hito*, "this person"), *あの人* (*a no hito*, "that person" if far from your listener) or *その人* (*so no hito*, "that person" if close to your listener).

Reading and writing

Reading and writing Japanese are advanced skills which take years of work to gain much real proficiency. Japanese people use three different writing systems of various complexity, two of which (***hiragana*** and ***katakana***) are syllabic and relatively easy to learn with 50 characters each.

The clincher is the set of Chinese characters known as ***kanji***, roughly 2,000 of which are in daily use while many more exist. The components of kanji originated as pictures representing concepts, and even though kanji have since evolved dramatically and many have long since

jettisoned any connection to the original concept, the meaning of a few simple kanji can still be guessed at (see below).

Kanji abbreviations

Kanji abbreviations can be tricky because readings different from their component words are liberally used. For example, railway line names may take a kanji from each city on their ends and apply different readings - you can understand them only after looking at kanjis used. Examples:

- Keisei (京成) Line: Tokyo (東京) and Narita (成田)
- Keihan (京阪) Line: Kyoto (京都) and Osaka (大阪)
- Suigun (水郡) Line: Mito (水戸) and Koriyama (郡山)

This convention may extend to other kanji-culture countries.

- Kanpu (関釜) Ferry connects Shimonoseki (下関) and Busan (釜山), South Korea.

One difficulty in reading Japanese lies often in the fact that a kanji can have **several different pronunciations**. The kanji 人 for example has the meaning of "person", and by itself it may be pronounced *hito*. The kanji 大 means "big" (imagine a person with outstretched arms) and can be pronounced as *dai* or *ō*. Together they form the word 大人 "adult" (lit. *big person*), which is pronounced *otona* — a pronunciation that has no relation to *dai*, *ō*, or *hito*. In the word 外国人 *gaikokujin* ("foreigner", lit. *outside country person*) the same kanji 人 is pronounced *jin*. These pronunciations exist because a single kanji may be used to write one or more different words, or parts of words. These "readings" are normally categorized as either Sino-Japanese (音読み *on'yomi*, a Japanese approximation of the Chinese pronunciation of the character at the time it was introduced to Japanese) or native Japanese (訓読み *kun'yomi*, based on the pronunciation of a native Japanese word). Generally, kanji are read with their native Japanese reading when on their own (eg. 話, *hanashi*) and with Sino-Japanese readings when part of compound words (eg. 電話, *denwa*), though there are many exceptions.

While knowing Chinese will give one a huge advantage in tackling kanji, and someone who knows Chinese would generally be able to guess the meanings of new kanji with about 70% accuracy, one should still be careful. While most characters have similar meanings in both Japanese and Chinese, there are a few which have drastically different meanings. For example, the word 手紙, literally "hand paper", means "toilet paper" (*shōuzhi*) in China, but "letter" (*tegami*) in Japan; 仕草 (*shigusa*) 'behaviour' is only in Japanese. A list of these terms with different

meanings can be referred in this Wiktionary page.

In addition, many kanji used in Japanese have since become less used in Chinese (e.g. 犬 *inu*, meaning "dog"), meaning that while a native speaker of Chinese would likely recognize them, foreign language learners of Chinese may not be familiar with these characters as they are rarely used outside of idioms, proverbs and compound words. Moreover, the difference between Chinese and Japanese syntax means that different combinations of kanji can also result in drastically different meanings with amusing results. For instance, the kanji for the Japanese surname *Inukai* (犬飼), which means "someone who raises dogs" in Japanese, will be interpreted as "to be raised by a dog" by a Chinese speaker.

Kanji are mixed with hiragana and katakana in everyday writing for historical reasons. Japan initially adopted Classical Chinese as its literary language, but later used Chinese characters as alphabets to suit Japanese grammar and syntax. Cursive forms of these characters were then simplified into hiragana by women in the imperial court, and their printed form into katakana by Buddhist monks.

Until 1946, Japanese used *Kyujitai* 'old script' is highly same to traditional Chinese (if you are not professional, you can say it is the same); but after it, Japanese uses *Shinjitai* 'new script', which became more different from simplified Chinese.

Shin.: 実

Kyu. and trad. Chinese: 實

Simp. Chinese: 实

Meaning: "real"

There are also several competing systems for rendering Japanese in the Latin alphabet, although the **Hepburn romanization** system is the most common and is used on Wikivoyage as well. Do not be surprised if you see these words romanized differently elsewhere.

Also note that there are many **homophones** in Japanese, i.e. words with different meanings that have the same pronunciation (like "there", "they're" and "their"). A common trope in manga, this can be confusing even to native speakers, to the extent that words have to be explained with an alternative reading or need to be drawn. These words may also employ a pitch-accent system to distinguish them, which speakers of

non-tonal languages may have difficulty learning to understand.

<i>hashi</i>	橋 "bridge"	端 "edge"	箸 "chopsticks"
<i>noboru</i>	登る "to climb"	昇る "to ascend"	上る "to go up"

For punctuation, it is very diverse between Japanese and Western-style.

Western (English)	Japanese	Note
.	。	
,	、	
!	!	No formal use in Japanese
?	?	
" " or ' '	「 」 or 『 』 “ ”	

Katakana

Katakana are used to write foreign and loanwords (except for those from Chinese, which are written in kanji) and are hence a good choice for travellers to learn. The katakana set of characters encompasses exactly the same sounds as hiragana; they only look different. The table on the left only reproduces the basic character set and diacritics (カ → ガ). Combinations (キャ) apply just as for hiragana. One additional sound though is ヴ *vu* and combinations like ヴェ *ve* based on it, accommodating additional foreign sounds. Every once in a while you may spot additional ingenious combinations or use of diacritics.

Since Japanese doesn't very well accommodate rapid successions of consonants, the katakana transcription can often only approximate the actual pronunciation of a foreign word. While some words like café (カフェ *kafe*) can be represented quite gracefully, other words like beer (ビール *bīru*) or rent-a-car (レンタカー *rentakā*) seem slightly strange to the native English speaker. Nonetheless, many English expressions and concepts are used in everyday life, as are a number of German, French, Dutch, Portuguese and Russian loanwords. In many cases, the original words are often abbreviated when used in Japanese, such as **supermarket** (スーパー *sūpā*), **department store** (デパート *depāto*), **remote control** (リモコン *rimokon*) or **television** (テレビ *terebi*). Oftentimes the exact meaning of a word has changed in Japanese

(German: *Arbeit* → アルバイト *arubaito* is used only for part-time work, and Russian: *икра* *ikra* → イクラ *ikura* is used only for salmon roe) or a completely new meaning was invented (ワンマンカー *wanmankā* → "one-man car", trains and buses without an inspector, only *one* driver), but you can usually at least guess at the meaning.

Due to post World War II American influences, by far the largest number of non-Chinese loan words in the Japanese language come from American English, but there are also loanwords from other languages: パン from Portuguese *pão* 'bread'; サボる 'to sabotage' from French *sabotage* 'sabotage'.

To identify a katakana word, it's usually helpful to repeat it out loud a few times and to leave out superfluous vowels, especially the 'u' in ス *su* and 'o' in ト *to*. That way ライス *raisu* quickly becomes "rice" and チケット *chiketto* becomes "ticket". Don't try too hard though, as sometimes original Japanese words are written in katakana as well, similar to the use of uppercase or italic letters in English. In addition, some words were not derived from English but from other languages such as German, French or Dutch.

Just like Japanese words from Chinese, beware of false friends written in katakana. For instance ヘルス *herusu*, from English "health", is actually a euphemism for prostitution that does not involve actual coitus. If you want to refer to health in the literal sense, the correct term would be 健康 *kenkō*.

Phrase list

Common signs

営業中 (*eigyōchū*)

Open

準備中 (*junbichū*)

Closed

入口 (*iriguchi*)

Entrance

出口 (*deguchi*)

Exit

大・中・小 (*dai / chū / shō*)

Large / Medium / Small

押す (*osu*)

Push

引く (*hiku*)

Pull

お手洗い (*o-tearai*), トイレ (*toire*), 化粧室 (*keshō-shitsu*)

Toilet

男 (*otoko*), 殿方 (*tonogata*)

Men

女 (*onna*), 婦人 (*fujin*)

Women

禁止 (*kinshi*)

Forbidden

円 (*en*)

Yen

Basics

Good afternoon.

こんにちは。 *Konnichiwa.* (*kon-nee-chee-wah*)

How are you?

お元気ですか? *O-genki desu ka?* (*Oh-GEN-kee dess-ka?*)

Fine, thank you.

はい、元気です。 *Hai, genki desu.* (*Ha-ee, gen-kee dess*)

How about you?

~さんは? *-san wa?* (*-san wa*) (insert the person's last name before "san")

What's your name? (lit. "Your name is...")

お名前は? *O-namae wa?* (*Oh-nah-mah-eh wah?*)

お名前は何とおっしゃいますか。 *O-namae wa nan to osshaimasu ka?*
(polite)

My name is

... です。 ... *desu*. (... *dess*.)

... といいます。 *to iimasu*.

... と申します。 ... *to mōshimasu*. (polite)

Nice to meet you. (formal)

はじめまして。どうぞ宜しくお願いします。 *Hajimemashite. Dōzo yoroshiku onegaishimasu*. (*Hah-jee-meh-mash-teh dohh-zoh yoh-roh-sh-ku oh-neh-gah-ee shee-mah-ss*)

Please. (request)

お願いします。 *Onegai shimasu*. (*oh-neh-gah-ee shee-mahs*)

Please. (offer)

どうぞ。 *Dōzo*. (*Dohh-zoh*)

This person is (when introducing somebody)

こちらは ... *Kochira wa ...* (*ko-chi-rah wah...*)

Thank you very much. (formal)

どうもありがとうございました。 *Dōmo arigatō gozaimashita*. (*doh-moh ah-ree-GAH-toh go-ZAh-ee-mah-shi-tah*)

Thank you. (less formal)

ありがとうございます。 *Arigatō gozaimasu*. (*ah-ree-GAH-toh go-ZAh-ee-mahs*)

Thank you. (normal)

ありがとう。 *Arigatō*. (*ah-ree-GAH-toh*)

Thanks. (informal)

どうも。 *Dōmo*. (*doh-moh*)

Thanks. (informal, Kansai)

おおきに。 *Ōkini* (*ohh-KEE-nee*)

You're welcome.

どういたしまして。 *Dō itashimashite*. (*doh EE-tah-shee mah-shteh*)

yes

はい。 *hai* (*High*)

no

いいえ。 *iie* (*EE-eh*)

Excuse me.

すみません。 *Sumimasen*. (*soo-mee-mah-sen*)

I'm sorry.

ごめんなさい。 *Gomen nasai*. (*goh-men-nah-sah-ee*)

I'm sorry. (informal)

ごめん *Gomen*. (*goh-men*)

Goodbye. (long-term)

さようなら。 Sayōnara. (sa-YOHH-nah-rah)

Goodbye. (informal)

じゃね。 Ja ne. (Jah-neh)

I can't speak Japanese (very well).

日本語が（よく）話せません。 Nihongo ga (yoku) hanasemasen. (nee-hohn-goh gah (yo-koo) hah-nah-seh-mah-sen)

Do you speak Japanese?

日本語が話せますか？ Nihongo ga hanasemasu ka? (ni-HON-go gah hah-nah-se-mahs-KAH?)

Yes, a little.

はい、少し。 Hai, sukoshi. (HIGH sko-shee)

Do you speak English?

英語が話せますか？ Eigo ga hanasemasu ka? (EHH-goh gah hah-nah-seh-mahs-KAH?)

Is there someone here who speaks English?

誰か英語が話せますか？ Dareka eigo ga hanasemasu ka? (dah-reh-kah EHH-goh gah hah-nah-seh-moss-KAH?)

Please speak slowly.

ゆっくり話してください。 Yukkuri hanashite kudasai. (YOO-kuree hanash-teh koo-dah-sah-ee)

Please say it again.

もう一度言ってください。 Mō ichido itte kudasai. (mo EE-chee-doh ee-te koo-dah-sah-ee)

Please help!

助けて！ Tasukete! (tahs-keh-teh!)

Look out!

危ない！ Abunai! (ah-boo-NIGH!)

Good morning.

お早うございます。 Ohayō gozaimasu. (oh-hah-YOH go-zah-ee-mahs)

Good morning. (informal)

おはよう。 Ohayō.

Good evening.

こんばんは。 Kompanwa. (kohn-bahn-wah)

Good night (to sleep)

お休みなさい。 Oyasuminasai. (oh-yah-soo-mee-nah-sigh)

Good night (to sleep) (informal)

お休み。 Oyasumi.

I don't understand.

分かりません。 *Wakarimasen.* (wah-kah-ree-mah-sen)

I am not Japanese.

日本人ではありません。 *Nihonjin dewa arimasen.* (nee-hon-jin deh-wah a-ree-ma-sehn)

Where is the toilet?

お手洗い・トイレはどこですか? *Otearai/toire wa doko desu ka?* (Oh-teh-ah-rah-ee/toh-ee-reh wah DOH-koh dess kah?)

What?

何? *Nani?* (nah-nee)

Where?

どこ? *Doko?* (doh-koh)

Who?

誰? *Dare?* (dah-reh)

When?

いつ? *Itsu?* (it-soo)

Which?

どれ? *Dore?* (doh-reh)

Why?

どうして *Dōshite* (doh-sh'teh)

How?

どうやって? *Dōyatte* (dohh-yah-teh)

How much?

いくら? *Ikura?* (ee-koo-rah)

What type of?

どんな? *Donna?* (dohn-nah)

Problems

What part of "no" don't you understand?

The Japanese are famously reluctant to say the word "no", and in fact the language's closest equivalent, いいえ *iee*, is largely limited to denying compliments you have received. ("Your Japanese is excellent! "Iie, it is very bad!"). But there are numerous other ways of expressing "no", so here are a few to watch out for.

いいです。

Ii desu.

結構です。

Kekkō desu.

"It's good," or "It's excellent." Used when you don't want more beer, don't want your *bentō* lunch microwaved, and are generally happy to keep things as they are. Accompany with teeth-sucking and handwaving to be sure to get your point across - both of these expressions may be interpreted as *positive* responses if you don't include enough nonverbal indications to the contrary.

ちょっと難しいです...

Chotto muzukashii desu...

Literally "it's a little difficult", but in practice "it's completely impossible." Often just abbreviated to sucking in air through teeth, saying "chotto" and looking pained. Take the hint.

申し訳ないですが...

Mōshiwakenai desu ga...

"This is inexcusable but..." But no. Used by sales clerks and such to tell you that you cannot do or have something.

ダメです。

Dame desu.

"It's no good." Used by equals and superiors to tell you that you cannot do or have something. The Kansai equivalent is *akan*.

違います。

Chigaimasu.

"It is different." What they really mean is "you're wrong". The casual form *chigau* and the Kansai contraction *chau* are also much used.

Leave me alone.

ほっといてくれ。 *Hottoitekure.*

Don't touch me!

さわらないで! *Sawaranaide!*

I'll call the police.

警察をよぶよ! *Keisatsu o yobu yo!*

Police!

警察! *Keisatsu!*

Stop! Thief!

動くな! 泥棒! *Ugokuna! Dorobō!*

I need your help.

手伝ってください。 *Tetsudatte kudasai.*

It's an emergency.

緊急です。 *Kinkyū desu.*

I'm lost.

道に迷っています。 *Michi ni mayotte imasu.*

I lost my bag.

鞆をなくしました。 *Kaban o nakushimashita.*

I dropped my wallet.

財布をおとしました。 *Saifu o otoshimashita.*

I'm sick.

病気です。 *Byōki desu.*

I don't feel well.

具合がわるいです。 *Guai ga warui desu.*

I've been injured.

怪我をしました。 *Kega o shimashita.*

Please call a doctor.

医者を呼んでください。 *Isha o yonde kudasai.*

Can I use your phone?

電話を使わせていただけますか？ *Denwa o tsukawasete itadakemasu ka?*

Medical emergencies

I need a doctor.

医者に見てもらいたいです。 *Isha ni mite moritai desu.*

Is there a doctor who can speak English?

英語の出来る医者はいいますか？ *Eigo no dekiru isha wa imasu ka?*

Please take me to a doctor.

医者に連れて行って下さい。 *Isha ni tsurete itte kudasai.*

My wife/husband/child is sick.

妻・旦那・子供が病気です。 *Tsuma/danna/kodomo ga byōki desu.*

Please call an ambulance.

救急車を呼んで下さい。 *Kyūkyūsha o yonde kudasai.*

I need first aid.

応急手当をして下さい。 *Ōkyū teate o shite kudasai.*

I need to go to the emergency room.

救急室に行かなければなりません。 *Kyūkyūshitsu ni ikanakereba narimasen.*

shorter: 救急室に行かないと。 *Kyūkyūshitsu ni ikanai to.*

How long will it take to get better?

治るのにどの位かかりますか? *Naoru no ni dono kurai kakarimasu ka?*

Where is a pharmacy?

薬局はどこですか? *Yakkyoku wa doko desu ka?*

Allergies

I'm allergic to

私は ... アレルギーです。 *Watashi wa ... arerugii desu.*

antibiotics

抗生物質 *kōsei busshitsu*

aspirin

アスピリン *asupirin*

codeine

コデイン *kodein*

dairy products

乳製品 *nyūseihin*

food coloring

人工着色料 *jinkō chakushokuryō*

fungus

菌類 *kinrui*

MSG

味の素 *ajinomoto*

mushrooms

キノコ *kinoko*

peanuts

ピーナッツ *pīnattsu*

penicillin

ペニシリン *penishirin*

pollen

花粉 *kafun*

seafood

魚介類 *gyokairui*

sesame

ゴマ *goma*

shellfish

貝類 *kairui*

tree nuts, fruits or berries

木の実 *kinomi*

wheat

小麦 *komugi*

Explaining symptoms

Body parts

head

頭 *atama*

face

顔 *kao*

eyes

目 *me*

ears

耳 *mimi*

nose

鼻 *hana*

throat

喉 *nodo*

chin

顎 *ago*

neck

首 *kubi*

shoulders

肩 *kata*

chest

胸 *mune*

waist

腰 *koshi*

arms

腕 *ude*

wrists

手首 *tekubi*

fingers

指 *yubi*

hands

手 *te*

elbow

肘 *hiji*

buttocks

(お)尻 *(o)shiri*

thigh

腿 *momo*

knee

膝 *hiza*

legs, foot

足 *ashi*

ankle

足首 <i>ashikubi</i> back 背中 <i>senaka</i>

... hurts.

... が痛い。... *ga itai.*

Feeling unwell.

気分が悪い。 *Kibun ga warui.*

Having a fever.

熱があります。 *Netsu ga arimasu.*

Coughing a lot.

咳がでます。 *Seki ga demasu.*

Feeling listless.

体がだるい。 *Karada ga darui.*

Feeling nauseated.

吐き気がします。 *Hakike ga shimasu.*

Feeling dizzy.

めまいがします。 *Memai ga shimasu.*

Having the chills.

寒気がします。 *Samuke ga shimasu.*

Swallowed something.

何かを吞んでしまいました。 *Nanika o nonde shimaimashita.*

Bleeding.

出血です。 *Shukketsu desu.*

Broken bone.

骨折です。 *Kossetsu desu.*

He/she is unconscious.

意識不明です。 *Ishiki fumei desu.*

Burned.

火傷です。 *Yakedo desu.*

Trouble breathing.

呼吸困難です。 *Kokyū konnan desu.*

Heart attack.

心臓発作です。 *Shinzō hossa desu.*

Vision worsened.

視力が落ちました。 *Shiryoku ga ochimashita.*

Cannot hear well.

耳がよく聞こえません。 *Mimi ga yoku kikoemasen.*

Nose bleeds a lot.

鼻血がよくでます。 *Hanaji ga yoku demasu.*

Extreme weather

Japan has more than its fair share of natural disasters.

Blizzard

吹雪 (*fubuki*)

Earthquake

地震 (*jishin*)

Flood

洪水 (*kōzui*)

Landslide

地滑り (*jisuberi*)

Tsunami

津波 (*tsunami*)

Typhoon

台風 (*taifū*)

Volcano eruption

噴火 (*funka*)

Numbers

While Arabic (Western) numerals are employed for most uses in Japan, you will occasionally still spot Japanese numerals at eg. markets and the menus of fancy restaurants. The characters used are nearly identical to Chinese numerals, and like Chinese, Japanese uses groups of 4 digits, not 3. "One million" is thus 百万 (*hyaku-man*), literally "hundred ten-thousands".

There are both native Japanese and Sino-Japanese readings for most numbers, but presented below are the more commonly used Sino-Japanese readings. Note that, due to superstition (*shi* also means "death"), the native Japanese readings *yon* and *nana* or 4 and 7 are used instead in most situations, though the Sino-Japanese readings *shi* and *shichi* respectively are more commonly used when counting.

Down for the count

When counting objects, Japanese uses special **counter** words. For example, "two bottles of beer" is ビール 2 本 *biiru nihon*, where *ni* is "two" and *-hon* means "bottles". Unlike in English, where counter words are often optional or non-existent, in Japanese they're mandatory whenever you count something (e.g. 車 2 台 *kuruma ni-dai*, two cars; 台 *dai* counts machines). Alas, the list of possible counters is vast, but some useful ones include:

[illegible]

small roundish objects (apples, sweets)

個 *-ko*

people

人 *-nin*, 名 *-mei* (polite), 名様 *-meisama* (humble polite; use for others, but not yourself)

small animals

匹 *-hiki, -biki, -piki*

large animals

頭 *-tō*

flat objects (papers, tickets)

枚 *-mai*

long objects (bottles, pens)

本 *-hon, -bon, -pon*

cups, glasses

杯 *-hai, -bai, -pai*

nights of a stay

泊 *-haku, -paku*

years (age)

歳 *-sai*

Note how many counters change form depending on the previous number: one, two, three glasses are *ippai, nihai, sanbai* respectively. There are also a few exceptions: one person and two people are *hitori* and *futari*. 20 years old is usually pronounced *hatachi*. You'll still be understood if you get these wrong though.

For numbers from one to nine, an old counting system is often used which applies to virtually any object you may want to count, without the need to attach a specific counter:

1

一つ *hitotsu*

2

二つ *futatsu*

3

三つ *mittsu*

4

四つ *yottsu*

5

五つ *itsutsu*

6

六つ *muttsu*

7

七つ *nanatsu*

8

八つ *yattsu*

9

九つ *kokonotsu*

10

十 *tou*

It is always a good idea to use a specific counter whenever possible, but using the generic numbers above is often equally acceptable. This system is rarely used anymore for numbers greater than nine.

Where they exist, the character(s) after the slash are used in financial contexts, such as when writing cheques and printing banknotes.

0

ゼロ (zero) or 〇 (*maru*) / 零 (*rei*) in finance

1

一 / 壱 (*ichi*)

2

二 / 弍 (*ni*)

3

三 / 参 (*san*)

4

四 (*yon* or *shi*)

5

五 (*go*)

6

六 (*roku*)

7

七 (*nana* or *shichi*)

8

八 (*hachi*)

9

九 (*kyū*)

10

十 / 拾 (*jū*)

11

十一 / 拾壱 (*jū-ichi*)

12

十二 / 拾弍 (*jū-ni*)

13

十三 / 拾参 (*jū-san*)

14

十四 / 拾四 (*jū-yon*)

15

十五 / 拾五 (*jū-go*)

16

十六 / 拾六 (*jū-roku*)

17

十七 / 拾七 (*jū-nana*)

18

十八 / 拾八 (*jū-hachi*)

19

十九 / 拾九 (*jū-kyū/jū-ku*)

20

二十 / 貳拾 (*ni-jū*)

21

二十一 / 貳拾壺 (*ni-jū-ichi*)

22

二十二 / 貳拾貳 (*ni-jū-ni*)

23

二十三 / 貳拾參 (*ni-jū-san*)

30

三十 / 參拾 (*san-jū*)

40

四十 / 四拾 (*yon-jū*)

50

五十 / 五拾 (*go-jū*)

60

六十 / 六拾 (*roku-jū*)

70

七十 / 七拾 (*nana-jū*)

80

八十 / 八拾 (*hachi-jū*)

90

九十 / 九拾 (*kyū-jū*)

100

百 (*hyaku*)

200

二百 / 貳百 (*nihyaku*)

300

三百 / 參百 (*sambyaku*)

600

六百 (*roppyaku*)

800

八百 (*happyaku*)

1000

千 (*sen*)

2000

二千 / 貳千 (*ni-sen*)

3000

三千 / 参千 (*san-zen*)

10,000

一万 / 壹万 (*ichi-man*)

1,000,000

百万 (*hyaku-man*)

100,000,000

一億 / 壹億 (*ichi-oku*)

1,000,000,000

十億 / 拾億 (*jū-oku*)

1,000,000,000,000

一兆 / 壹兆 (*itchō*)

0.5

〇・五 (*rei ten go*)

0.56

〇・五六 (*rei ten go-roku*)

number _____ (train, bus, etc.)

_____番 (_____ *ban*)

half

半分 (*hambun*)

less (few)

少ない (*sukunai*)

more (many)

多い (*ōi*)

Time

now

今 (*ima*)

later

後で (*atode*)

before

前に (*mae ni*)

before ____

____ の前に (____ *no mae ni*)

morning

朝 (*asa*) (colloquial) / 午前 (*gozen*) (formal)

noon

昼 (*hiru* or *o-hiru*) / 正午 (*shōgo*)

afternoon

昼 (*hiru* or *hiruma*) (colloquial) / 午後 (*gogo*) (formal)

evening before sunset

夕方 (*yūgata*)

night or after sunset

夜 (*yoru*)

midnight or past 12AM

真夜中 (*mayonaka*)

Clock time

Clock times are formed as Chinese numeral plus 時 *ji*, for example, *goji* 5時/五時 for five o'clock. The exception is four o'clock which is pronounced *yoji* (四時) instead of *shiji*. You will be understood if you simply substitute *gozen* 午前 for "AM" and *gogo* 午後 for PM, although other time qualifiers like 朝 *asa* for morning, 昼 *hiru* for afternoon and 夜 *yoru* for night sound more natural. The 24-hour clock is also commonly used in official contexts such as train schedules. TV schedules occasionally use a modified 24-hour clock, with late night showtimes counted from the previous day, e.g. Monday at 26:00 indicates **Tuesday** at 2:00 AM.

six o'clock in the morning

朝6時 (*asa rokuji*)

nine o'clock AM

午前9時 (*gozen kuji*)

noon

正午 (*shōgo*)

one o'clock PM

午後1時 (*gogo ichiji*.)

two o'clock PM

午後2時 (*gogo niji*)

midnight

夜12時 (*yoru jūniji*), 零時 / 0時 (*rēji*), 24時(*nijū yo ji*)

Duration

Confusingly, the Japanese words for "N days" (long) and "Nth day" are the same, so eg. 二日 *futsuka* means both "two days" and "the second day of the month". (See #Days of the month for the full list.) You can tag on -間 *kan* at the end, eg. *futsukakan* 二日間, to clarify that you mean "two days long". The exception is 一日, which is read *ichinichi* to mean "one day/all day", but *tsuitachi* to mean "first day". Also note that 一日間 *ichinichikan* is not used, and the term for a duration of one day is simply 一日 *ichinichi*.

_____ **second(s)**

_____ 秒 (*byō*)

_____ **minute(s)**

_____ 分 (*fun* or *pun*)

_____ **hour(s)**

_____ 時間 (*jikan*)

_____ **day(s)**

_____ 日間 (*nichikan* or (*k*)*kakan*, see note above, except for 一日 (one day))

_____ **week(s)**

_____ 週間 (*shūkan*)

_____ **month(s)**

_____ ケ月 (*kagetsu*)

_____ **year(s)**

_____ 年間 (*nenkan*)

Days

today

今日 (*kyō*)

yesterday

昨日 (*kinō*)

the day before yesterday

おととい (*ototoi*)

tomorrow

明日 (*ashita*) (colloquial) / 明日 (*asu*) (formal)

the day after tomorrow

あさって (*asatte*)

_____ **days after tomorrow**

_____ 日後 (*nichigo* or (*k*)*kago*, see note above)

this week

今週 (*konshū*)

last week

先週 (*senshū*)

next week

来週 (*raishū*)

Days of the week

The days of the week are named after the sun, the moon and the five elements of Chinese philosophy.

Sunday

日曜日 (*nichiyōbi*), abbreviated 日 (*nichi*)

Monday

月曜日 (*getsuyōbi*), abbreviated 月 (*getsu*)

Tuesday

火曜日 (*kayōbi*), abbreviated 火 (*ka*)

Wednesday

水曜日 (*suiyōbi*), abbreviated 水 (*sui*)

Thursday

木曜日 (*mokuyōbi*), abbreviated 木 (*moku*)

Friday

金曜日 (*kin'yōbi*), abbreviated 金 (*kin*)

Saturday

土曜日 (*doyōbi*), abbreviated 土 (*do*)

Days of the month

The 1st through the 10th of the month have special names:

First day of the month

1日 (*tsu'itachi*)

Second day of the month

2日 (*futsuka*)

Third day of the month

3日 (*mikka*)

Fourth day of the month

4日 (*yokka*)

Fifth day of the month

5日 (*itsuka*)

Sixth day of the month

6日 (*mu'ika*)

Seventh day of the month

7日 (*nanoka*)

Eighth day of the month

8日 (*yōka*)

Ninth day of the month

9日 (*kokonoka*)

Tenth day of the month

10日 (*tōka*)

The other days of the month are more orderly, just add the suffix *-nichi* to the ordinal number. Note that 14, 20, and 24 deviate from this pattern.

Eleventh day of the month

11日 (*jū'ichinichi*)

Fourteenth day of the month

14日 (*jū'yokka*)

Twentieth day of the month

20日 (*hatsuka*)

Twenty-fourth day of the month

24日 (*nijū'yokka*)

Months

Months are very orderly in Japanese, just add the suffix *-gatsu* to the Sino-Japanese ordinal number.

January

1月 (*ichigatsu*)

February

2月 (*nigatsu*)

March

3月 (*sangatsu*)

April

4月 (*shigatsu*)

May

5月 (*gogatsu*)

June

6月 (*rokugatsu*)

July

7月 (*shichigatsu*)

August

8月 (*hachigatsu*)

September

9月 (*kugatsu*)

October

10月 (*jūgatsu*)

November

11月 (*jūichigatsu*)

December

12月 (*jūnigatsu*)

Seasons

Spring

春 (*haru*)

Summer

夏 (*natsu*)

Rainy season

梅雨 (*tsuyu, bai'u*)

Autumn

秋 (*aki*)

Winter

冬 (*fuyu*)

Writing time and date

Dates are written in year/month/day (day of week) format, with markers:

2007年3月21日(火)

In Japanese, the year is read as an ordinary number with exception of "9 as the last digit". 1999 was "one thousand nine hundred ninety-nine", *sen kyū-hyaku kyū-jū ku nen*). It can sometimes be abbreviated to the last two digits (i.e. "ninety-nine", *kyū-jū ku nen*), while pronouncing it *kyū-jū kyū nen* refers to "for the duration of 99 years", rather the year.)

Note that **Imperial era years**, based on the name and duration of the current Emperor's reign, are also frequently used. 2020 in the Gregorian calendar corresponds to **Reiwa 2** 令和2年, which may be abbreviated as "R2" or 令2. Dates like "02/03/24" (Reiwa 2, March 24) are also occasionally seen. Meiji, Taishō, Shōwa, and Heisei are used by elderly people or popular on signboards at historical sights. To convert the year

into Gregorian calendar:

Reiwa 令和 (1 May 2019 –)

add 2018 to the year in Reiwa, i.e. *Reiwa 3 nen* 令和3年 is 2021 in the Gregorian calendar.

Heisei 平成 (8 January 1989 – 30 April 2019)

minus 12 from the year in Heisei and add 2000, i.e. *Heisei 12 nen* 平成12年 is 2000 in Gregorian calendar.

Shōwa 昭和 (25 December 1926 – 7 January 1989)

plus 1925 to the year in Shōwa, i.e. *Shōwa 45 nen* 昭和45年 is 1970 in Gregorian calendar.

Taishō 大正 (30 July 1912 – 25 December 1926)

plus 1911 to the year in Taishō, i.e. *Taishō 9 nen* 大正9年 is 1920 in Gregorian calendar.

Meiji 明治 (28 October 1868 – 30 July 1912)

minus 33 from the year in Meiji and add 1900, i.e. *Meiji 33 nen* 明治33年 is 1900 in Gregorian calendar.

Colors

Many of the English words for colors are widely used and understood by almost all Japanese. These are indicated after the slash.

Note that some Japanese colors are normally suffixed with *-iro* (色) to distinguish between the color and the object. For example, 茶 *cha* means "tea", but 茶色 *chairo* means "tea-color" → "brown".

black

黒 / ブラック (*kuro / burakku*)

white

白 / ホワイト (*shiro / howaito*)

gray

灰(色) / グレー (*hai(iro) / gurē*)

red

赤 / レッド (*aka / reddo*)

blue

青 / ブルー (*ao / burū*)

yellow

黄(色) / イエロー (*ki(iro) / ierō*)

green

緑 / グリーン (*midori / guriin*)

orange

橙 / オレンジ (*daidai / orenji*)

purple

紫 / パープル (*murasaki / pāpuru*)

pink

桃(色) / ピンク (*momo(iro) / pinku*)

brown

茶(色) / ブラウン (*cha(iro) / buraun*)

silver

銀(色) / シルバー (*gin(iro) / sirubā*)

gold

金(色) / ゴールド (*kin(iro) / gōrudo*)

Transportation

Bus and train

bus

バス (*basu*)

train

電車 (*densha*)

metro / subway

地下鉄 (*chikatetsu*)

tram / streetcar

路面電車 (*romendensha*)

light rail

ライトレール (*raito rēru*)

bullet train

新幹線 (*shinkansen*)

How much is a ticket to _____?

_____ までいくらですか? (*_____ made ikura desu ka?*)

One ticket to _____, please.

_____ まで一枚お願いします。(*_____ made ichimai onegaishimasu.*)

Where does this train/bus go?

この電車・バスはどこ行きですか? (*Kono densha/basu wa doko yuki desu ka?*)

Where is the train/bus to _____?

_____ 行きの電車・バスはどこですか? (*_____ yuki no densha/basu wa doko desu ka?*)

Does this train/bus stop in _____?

この電車・バスは _____ に止まりますか? (*Kono densha/basu wa _____ ni tomarimasu ka?*)

When does the train/bus for _____ leave?

_____ 行きの電車・バスは何時に出発しますか? (*_____ yuki no densha/basu wa nanji ni shuppatsu shimasu ka?*)

When will this train/bus arrive in _____?

この電車・バスは何時に _____ に着きますか? (*Kono densha/basu wa nanji ni _____ ni tsukimasu ka?*)

Directions

How do I get to _____?

_____ はどちらですか? (*_____ wa dochira desu ka?*)

...the train station?

駅...? (*eki...*)

...the bus station?

バス停...? (*basu tei...*)

...the airport?

空港...? (*kūkō...*)

...downtown?

街の中心...? (*machi no chūshin...*)

...the youth hostel?

ユースホステル...? (*yūsu hosuteru...*)

...the _____ hotel?

_____ ホテル...? (*hoteru...*)

...the _____ embassy/consulate?

_____ 大使館/領事館...? (*_____ taishikan/ryōjikan...*)

Where are there a lot of _____

_____ が多い所はどこですか? (*_____ ga ooi tokoro wa doko desu ka?*)

...lodgings?

宿...? (*yado...*)

...restaurants?

レストラン...? (*resutoran...*)

...bars?

バー...? (*baa...*)

...sites to see?

見物...? (*mimono...*)

Where is _____?

_____ はどこですか? (*_____ wa doko desu ka?*)

Is it far from here?

ここから遠いですか? (*Koko kara tooi desu ka?*)

Please show me on the map.

地図で指して下さい。 (*Chizu de sashite kudasai.*)

street

道 (*michi*)

Turn left.

左へ曲がってください。 (*Hidari e magatte kudasai.*)

Turn right.

右へ曲がってください。 (*Migi e magatte kudasai.*)

left

左 (*hidari*)

right

右 (*migi*)

in front of the _____

_____の前 (_____ *no mae*)

behind the _____

_____の後ろ (_____ *no ushiro*)

straight ahead

まっすぐ (*massugu*)

towards the _____

_____へ向かって (*e mukatte*)

past the _____

_____の先 (*no saki*)

before the _____

_____の前 (*no mae*)

Watch for the _____.

_____が目印です。 (*ga mejirushi desu.*)

intersection

交差点 (*kōsaten*)

traffic light

信号 (*shingou*)

inside

中 (*naka*)

outside

外 (*soto*)

north

北 (*kita*)

south

南 (*minami*)

east

東 (*higashi*)

west

西 (*nishi*)

uphill

上り (*nobori*), also used for trains heading towards Tokyo

downhill

下り (*kudari*), also used for trains coming from Tokyo

Taxi

Taxi!

タクシー! (*takushī!*)

Take me to _____, please.

_____までお願いします。 (*_____ made onegaishimasu.*)

How much does it cost to get to _____?

_____までいくらですか? (*_____ made ikura desu ka*)

Take me there, please.

そこまでお願いします。 (*soko made onegaishimasu.*)

Lodging

Do you have any rooms available?

空いてる部屋ありますか? (*Aiteru heya arimasu ka?*)

How much is a room for one person/two people?

一人・二人用の部屋はいくらですか? (*Hitori/futari-yō no heya wa ikura desu ka?*)

Is the room Japanese/Western style?

和室/洋室ですか? (*Washitsu/yōshitsu desu ka?*)

Does the room come with...

部屋は ... 付きですか? (*Heya wa _____ tsuki desu ka?*)

...bedsheets?

シーツ...? (*shītsu...*)

...a bathroom?

風呂場...? (*furoba...*)

...a telephone?

電話...? (*denwa...*)

...a TV?

テレビ? (*terebi...*)

May I see the room first?

部屋を見てもいいですか? (*Heya o mite mo ii desu ka?*)

Do you have anything quieter?

もっと[静かな]部屋ありますか? (*Motto [shizuka na] heya arimasu ka?*)

...bigger?

広い...? (*hiroii...*)

...cleaner?

きれいな...? (*kirei na...*)

...cheaper?

安い...? (*yasui...*)

OK, I'll take it.

はい、これでいいです。(*Hai, kore de ii desu.*)

I will stay for _____ night(s).

_____ 晩泊まります。(*_____ ban tomarimasu.*)

Do you know another place to stay?

他の宿はご存知ですか? (*Hoka no yado wa gozonji desu ka?*)

Do you have [a safe?]

[金庫]ありますか? (*[Kinko] arimasu ka?*)

...lockers?

戸棚...? (*todana...?*)

Is breakfast/supper included?

朝食・夕食は付きますか? (*Chōshoku/yūshoku wa tsukimasu ka?*)

What time is breakfast/supper?

朝食・夕食は何時ですか? (*Chōshoku/yūshoku wa nanji desu ka?*)

Please clean my room.

部屋を掃除してください。(*Heya o sōji shite kudasai.*)

Please wake me at _____.

_____ に起こしてください。(*_____ ni okoshite kudasai.*)

I want to check out.

チェックアウトです。(*Chekku auto (check out) desu.*)

Money

Do you accept American/Australian/Canadian dollars?

アメリカ/オーストラリア/カナダドルは使えますか? (*Amerika/ōsutoraria/kanada doru wa tsukaemasu ka?*)

Do you accept British pounds?

イギリスポンドは使えますか? (*Igirisu pondo wa tsukaemasu ka?*)

Do you accept credit cards?

クレジットカードは使えますか? (*Kurejitto kaado (credit card) wa tsukaemasu ka?*)

Can you change money for me?

お金両替できますか? (*Okane ryōgae dekimasu ka?*)

Where can I get money changed?

お金はどこで両替できますか? (*Okane wa doko de ryōgae dekimasu ka?*)

Can you change a traveler's check for me?

トラベラーズチェックを両替できますか? (*Torabarāsu chekku (traveler's check) wo ryōgae dekimasu ka?*)

Where can I get a traveler's check changed?

トラベラーズチェックはどこで両替できますか? (*Torabarāzu chekku (traveler's check) wa doko de ryōgae dekimasu ka?*)

What is the exchange rate?

為替レートはいくらですか? (*Kawase rēto wa ikura desu ka?*)

Where is an automatic teller machine (ATM)?

ATM はどこにありますか? (*ATM wa doko ni arimasuka?*)

Eating

What are they yelling at me?

Most Japanese restaurants show their appreciation for customers by loudly greeting them in unison. Expect to hear the following:

Irasshai! or Irasshaimase!

"Come on in!", said when a customer walks in. You're not expected to respond in any way, just take a seat.

Arigatō gozaimashita!

"Thank you very much!", said when a customer leaves.

If your meal was good, thank the chef or staff with *Gochisōsama deshita* when leaving, and you'll get an extra-hearty thank you in return!

I'm hungry.

お腹がすきました。 (*Onaka ga sukimashita.*)

A table for one person/two people, please.

一人・二人です。 (*Hitori/futari desu.*)

Please bring a menu.

メニューを下さい。 (*Menu wo kudasai.*)

Can I look in the kitchen?

調理場を見てもいいですか? (*Chōriba wo mite mo ii desu ka?*)

Is there a house specialty?

お勧めはありますか？ (O-susume wa arimasu ka?)

Is there a local specialty?

この辺の名物がありますか？ (Kono hen no mēbutsu wa arimasu ka?)

Please choose for me.

お任せします。 (O-makase shimasu.)

I'm a vegetarian.

ベジタリアンです。 (Bejitarian desu.)

I don't eat pork.

豚肉はだめです。 (Butaniku wa dame desu.)

I don't eat beef.

牛肉はだめです。 (Gyūniku wa dame desu.)

I don't eat raw fish.

生の魚はだめです。 (Nama no sakana wa dame desu.)

Please do not use too much oil.

油を控えて下さい。 (Abura wo hikaete kudasai.)

fixed-price meal

定食 (teishoku)

à la carte

一品料理 (ippinryōri)

breakfast

朝食 (chōshoku) / 朝ご飯 (asagohan)

lunch

昼食 (chūshoku) / 昼ご飯 (hirugohan)

light meal/snack

軽食 (keishoku) / おやつ (oyatsu)

supper

夕食 (yūshoku) / 晩ご飯 (bangohan)

Please bring ____.

____ を下さい。 (____ wo kudasai.)

I want a dish containing ____.

____ が入ってるものを下さい。 (____ ga haitteru mono wo kudasai.)

chicken

鶏肉 (toriniku) / チキン (chikin)

beef

牛肉 (gyūniku) / ビーフ (bīfu)

pork

豚肉 (butaniku) / ポーク (pōku)

mutton

マトン (*maton*) / 羊肉 (*yōniku*)

lamb

ラム(肉) (*ramu(-niku)*)

fish

魚 (*sakana*)

ham

ハム (*hamu*)

sausage

ソーセージ (*sōsēji*)

cheese

チーズ (*chīzu*)

eggs

卵 / 玉子 (*tamago*)

salad

サラダ (*sarada*)

(fresh) vegetables

(新鮮な)野菜 ((*shinsen-na*) *yasai*)

(fresh) fruit

(新鮮な)果物 ((*shinsen-na*) *kudamono*)

bread

パン (*pan*)

toast

トースト (*tōsuto*)

noodles

麺類 (*menrui*)

pasta

パスタ (*pasuta*)

cooked rice

ご飯 (*gohan*)

raw rice

米 (*kome*)

soup

スープ : (*sūpu*)

beans

豆 (*mame*)

May I have a glass/cup of _____?

_____ を一杯下さい。(_____ *wo ippai kudasai.*)

May I have a bottle of _____?

_____ を一本下さい。(_____ *wo ippon kudasai.*)

coffee

コーヒー (*kōhī*)

green tea

緑茶(*ryokucha*) / お茶 (*ocha*)

black tea

紅茶 (*kōcha*)

juice

ジュース(*jūsu*) / 果汁 (*kajū*)

milk

ミルク (*miruku*) / 牛乳 (*gyūnyū*) (The latter specifically refers to cow's milk.)

water

水 (*mizu*)

beer

ビール (*bīru*)

red/white wine

赤/白ワイン (*aka/shiro wain*)

Do you have _____?

_____ ありますか? (_____ *wa arimasu ka?*)

chopsticks

お箸 (*o-hashī*)

fork

フォーク (*fōku*)

spoon

スプーン (*supūn*)

sugar

砂糖 (*satō*)

salt

塩 (*shio*)

black pepper

胡椒 (*koshō*)

soy sauce

醤油 (*shōyu*)

ashtray

灰皿 (*haizara*)

Excuse me, waiter? (getting attention of server)

すみません。 (*sumimasen*)

(when starting a meal)

いただきます。 (*itadakimasu*)

It was delicious. (when finishing a meal)

ご馳走さまでした。 (*Gochisōsama deshita.*)

Please clear the plates.

お皿を下げてください。 (*Osara o sagete kudasai.*)

The check, please.

お勘定お願いします。 (*O-kanjo onegaishimasu.*) / 会計お願いします。
(*Kaikei onegaishimasu*)

On the phone

Telephone

電話 *denwa*

Mobile phone

携帯(電話) *kētai(denwa)*

Telephone number

電話番号 *denwa bangō*

Phone book

電話帳 *denwa chō*

Answering machine

留守番電話 *rusuban denwa*

Hello (only on the phone)

もしもし *moshi moshi*

May I speak to

... をお願いします。 ... *wo onegaishimasu.*

Is ... there?

... はいらっしゃいますか? ... *wa irasshaimasu ka?*

Who is calling?

どなたですか? *Donata desu ka?*

One moment, please.

ちょっとお待ちください。 *Chotto omachi kudasai.*

... is not here right now.

... は今いません。 ... *wa ima imasen.*

I will call you again later.

後でまた電話します。 *Ato de mata denwa shimasu.*

I got the wrong number.

間違えました。 *Machigaemashita.*

The line is busy.

話し中です。 *Hanashichū desu.*

What is your phone number?

電話番号は何番ですか? *Denwa bangō wa nanban desu ka?*

Bars

Sake talk

Sake, known in Japanese as 日本酒 *nihonshu*, has a vocabulary all its own. Here is a brief introduction.

atsukan

熱燗 Heated sake. Recommended only in winter with cheap sake.

nurukan

ぬる燗 Heated sake in luke warm temperature below 40C. Recommended for any season with average sake.

hiya

冷や Sake at room temperature.

Note: *ohiya* お冷や means cold/iced water.

reishu

冷酒 Chilled sake. The way to drink better sake.

choko

ちょこ A tiny gulp-sized ceramic cup for sake.

masu

升 A square wooden box traditionally used to drink chilled sake, also contains one *gō*. Drink from the corner. Also used as a "spiller" to overflow your glass of *hiya* as a compliment. You can prevent to spill by sipping with the masu placed on the table.

tokkuri

徳利 A small ceramic jug used to pour sake, contains around one or two *gō/gōs*

ichigō

一合 The standard measure for servings of sake, around 180 milliliters.

isshōbin

一升瓶 The standard sake bottle, containing 10 *gō*, ie. 1.8 liters.

Do you serve alcohol?

お酒ありますか? (*O-sake arimasu ka?*)

Is there table service?

テーブルサービスありますか? (*Tēburu sābisu arimasu ka?*)

A beer/two beers, please.

ビール一杯・二杯下さい。 (*Biiru ippai/nihai kudasai.*)

A glass of red/white wine, please.

赤・白ワイン一杯下さい。(Aka/shiro wain ippai kudasai.)

A mug (of beer), please.

(ビールの)ジョッキ下さい。(Bīru no) jokki kudasai.)

A bottle, please.

ビン下さい。(Bin kudasai.)

_____ (hard liquor) and _____ (mixer), please.

_____ と _____ 下さい。(_____ to _____ kudasai.)

sake

日本酒 (nihonshu)

Japanese liquor

焼酎 (shōchū)

whiskey

ウイスキー (uisukii)

vodka

ウォッカ (wokka)

rum

ラム (ramu)

water

水 (mizu)

club soda

ソーダ (sōda)

tonic water

トニックウォーター (tonikku wōtā)

orange juice

オレンジジュース (orenji jūsu)

cola (soda)

コーラ (kōra)

with ice

オンザロック (onzarokku (on the rocks))

Do you have any bar snacks?

おつまみありますか? (O-tsumami arimasu ka?)

One more, please.

もう一つください。(Mō hitotsu kudasai.)

Another round, please.

みんなに同じものを一杯ずつください。(Minna ni onaji mono o ippai zutsu kudasai.)

When is closing time?

閉店は何時ですか? (*Heiten wa nanji desuka?*)

Shopping

O, honorable prefix!

Nearly any Japanese word can be prefixed with the respectful tags *o-* (お) or *go-* (ご or 御), often translated with the unwieldy four-syllable word "honorable". A few you might expect — *o-tōsan* (お父さん) is "honorable father", and a few you might not — *o-shiri* (お尻) is "honorable buttocks". Most of the time, they're used to emphasize that the speaker is referring to the listener, so if someone enquires if after your honorable health (お元気 *o-genki*) it's proper to strip off the honorific and reply that you are merely *genki*. However, for some words like *gohan* (ご飯) "rice" and *ocha* (お茶) "tea", the prefix is inseparable and should always be used. In this phrasebook, the prefix is separated with a hyphen if it's optional (*o-kane*), and joined to the word if it's mandatory (*oisha*).

Do you have this in my size?

私のサイズでありますか? (*Watashi no saizu de arimasu ka?*)

How much is this?

いくらですか? (*Ikura desu ka?*)

That's too expensive.

高過ぎます。(*Takasugimasu.*)

Would you take _____?

_____円(で)はどうですか? (_____ *yen (de) wa dō desu ka?*)

expensive

高い (*takai*)

cheap

安い (*yasui*)

I can't afford it.

そんなにお金がありません。(*Sonna ni okane ga arimasen.*)

I don't want it.

要りません。(*Irimasen.*)

You're cheating me, aren't you?

騙してるでしょう? (*Damashiteru deshō?*) **Use with caution!**

I'm not interested.

興味ありません。(*Kyōmi arimasen.*)

OK, I'll take it.

はい、それにします。(*Hai, sore ni shimasu.*)

Can I have a bag?

袋を貰えますか? (*Fukuro o moraemasu ka?*) or 袋をください (*Fukuro o kudasai*)

Do you ship (overseas)?

海外へ発送出来ますか? (*Kaigai e hassō dekimasu ka?*)

I need...

___が欲しいです。 (___ *ga hoshii desu.*)

...spectacles.

眼鏡 (*megane*)

...toothpaste.

歯磨き粉 (*hamigakiko*)

...a toothbrush.

歯ブラシ (*ha-burashi*)

...tampons.

タンポン (*tampon*)

...soap.

洗剤 (*senzai*, liquid or powder), 石鹸 (*sekken*, bar soap)

...shampoo.

シャンプー (*shampū*)

...pain reliever. (e.g., aspirin or ibuprofen)

鎮痛剤 (*chintsūzai*)

...cold medicine.

風邪薬 (*kazegusuri*)

...stomach medicine.

胃腸薬 (*ichōyaku*)

...a razor.

剃刀 (*kamisori*)

...an umbrella.

傘 (*kasa*)

...sunblock lotion.

日焼け止め (*hiyakedome*)

...a postcard.

葉書 (*hagaki*)

...postage stamps.

切手 (*kitte*)

...batteries.

電池 (*denchi*)

...writing paper.

紙 (*kami*)

...a pen.

ペン (*pen*)

...a pencil.

鉛筆 (*empitsu*)

...English-language books.

英語の本 (*eigo no hon*)

...English-language magazines.

英語の雑誌 (*eigo no zasshi*)

...an English-language newspaper.

英字新聞 (*ēji shinbun*)

...a Japanese-English dictionary.

和英辞典 (*waē jiten*)

...an English-Japanese dictionary.

英和辞典 (*ēwa jiten*)

Family

Are you married?

結婚していますか? (*Kekkon shiteimasu ka?*)

I am married.

結婚しています。 (*Kekkon shiteimasu.*)

I am single.

独身です。 (*Dokushin desu*)

Do you have brothers and sisters?

兄弟はいますか? (*Kyōdai wa imasu ka?*)

Do you have children?

子供はいますか? (*Kodomo wa imasu ka?*)

Talking about your own family

Family ties

In Japanese, it's always important to use less respectful terms for your own family and more respectful terms for another's family. Note also that the words for older/younger brother/sister are different.

Father

父 (*chichi*)

Mother

母 (*haha*)

Older Brother

兄 (*ani*)

Older Sister

姉 (*ane*)

Younger Brother

弟 (*otōto*)

Younger Sister

妹 (*imōto*)

Grandfather

祖父 (*sofu*)

Grandmother

祖母 (*sobo*)

Uncle

叔父/伯父 (*oji*)

Aunt

叔母/伯母 (*oba*)

Husband

夫 (*otto*) / 主人 (*shujin*)

Wife

妻 (*tsuma*) / 家内 (*kanai*)

Son

息子 (*musuko*)

Daughter

娘 (*musume*)

Grandchild

孫 (*mago*)

Talking about another's family**Father**

お父さん (*otōsan*)

Mother

お母さん (*okāsan*)

Older Brother

お兄さん (*onīsan*)

Older Sister

お姉さん (*onēsan*)

Younger Brother

弟さん (*otōtosan*)

Younger Sister

妹さん (*imōtosan*)

Grandfather

おじいさん (*ojīsan*)

Grandmother

おばあさん (*obāsan*)

Uncle

おじさん (*ojisan*)

Aunt

おばさん (*obasan*)

Husband

ご主人 (*goshujin*)

Wife

奥さん (*okusan*)

Son

息子さん (*musukosan*)

Daughter

お嬢さん (*ojōsan*)

Grandchild

お孫さん (*omagosan*)

Driving

I want to rent a car.

レンタカーをお願いします。 (*Rentakā (rent-a-car) onegaishimasu.*) 0:01

Can I get insurance?

保険入れますか? (*Hoken hairemasu ka?*) 0:12

Do you have a driver's license?

免許証を持っていますか? (*Menkyoshō wo motteimasu ka?*) 0:38

stop (on a street sign)

止まれ / とまれ (*tomare*) 0:40

one way

一方通行 (*ippō tsūkō*) 0:51

caution

徐行 (*jokō*) 1:05

road blocked

通行止め (*tsūkōdome*) 1:16

no parking

駐車禁止 (*chūsha kinshi*) 1:20

speed limit

制限速度 (*seigen sokudo*) 1:23

gas (petrol) station

ガソリンスタンド (*gasorin sutando*) 1:40

petrol

ガソリン (*gasorin*) 52:33

diesel

軽油/ディーゼル (*keiyu / diizeru*) 1:02:31

Authority

In Japan, you can legally be incarcerated for twenty-three (23) days before you are charged, but you do have the right to see a lawyer after the first 48 hours of detention. Note that if you sign a confession, you *will* be convicted.

I haven't done anything (wrong).

何も(悪いことを)していません。 (*Nani mo (warui koto wo) shiteimasen.*)

It was a misunderstanding.

誤解でした。 (*Gokai deshita.*)

Where are you taking me?

どこへ連れて行くのですか? (*Doko e tsurete yukuno desu ka?*)

Am I under arrest?

私は逮捕されてるのですか? (*Watashi wa taiho sareteruno desu ka?*)

I am a citizen of ____.

____ の国民です。 (*____ no kokumin desu.*)

I want to meet with the ____ embassy.

____ 大使館と会わせて下さい。 (*____ taishikan to awasete kudasai.*)

I want to meet with a lawyer.

弁護士と会わせて下さい。 (*Bengoshi to awasete kudasai.*)

Can it be settled with a fine?

罰金で済みますか? (*Bakkin de sumimasu ka?*)

Note: You can say this to a traffic cop, but bribery is highly unlikely to work in Japan.

Typical Japanese expressions

Four syllable words

If words can be shortened, Japanese will inevitably shorten them. Two by two syllables is often the sweet spot, and sometimes it's hard to guess where those came from.

コンビニ *konbini*

→ コンビニエンスストア *konbiniensu sutoa*, convenience store.

デジカメ *deji kame*

→ デジタルカメラ *dejitaru kamera*, a digital camera.

パソコン *pasokon*

→ パーソナルコンピューター *pāsonaru konpyūtā*, a personal computer. ノート *nōto* stands for notebooks.

プリクラ *purikura*

→ プリントクラブ *purinto kurabu* or "print club". A sort of extremely flashy photo booth and a favourite pastime for many.

リモコン *rimokon*

→ リモートコントロール *rimōto kontorōru*, remote control

ケイワイ *kei wai*

→ 空気読めない *kūki yomenai*, "can't read the air", meaning an unperceptive person who can't read between the lines/can't keep up with a conversation.

そうですね。 *Sō desu ne.*

"That's how it is, isn't it?"

General agreement. Especially old people can be heard going *sō desu ne* back and forth quite a few times.

(大変) お待たせしました。 (*Taihen*) *omataseshimashita.*

"I have made you wait (terribly) long."

Used as an excuse after any amount of downtime, even just seconds. Often also used as a starter to get things going again.

お疲れさまでした。 *Otsukaresama deshita.*

"It's been honorably tiresome."

To colleagues in the sense of "you gave it all, good work", but more generally at the end of almost any activity.

頑張って! *Ganbatte!*

"Give it your best!"

Meant to be encouraging and motivating. 頑張れ! *Ganbare!* in stronger cheering.

いただきます。 *Itadakimasu.*

"I will receive."

To yourself before starting to eat or when accepting something offered to you.

失礼します。 *Shitsurei shimasu.*

"I will trouble you." or "I will be impolite."

When entering your superiors room or an unfamiliar house, when trying to get someone's attention or generally when interrupting someone.

失礼しました。 **Shitsurei shimashita.**

"I have troubled you." or "Excuse my impoliteness."

When leaving your superiors room or an unfamiliar house or generally as "Sorry to have bothered you, carry on."

大丈夫。 **Daijōbu.**

"It is alright."

For general reassurance. Used with *desu ka?* to inquire if something or somebody is alright.

凄い! **Sugoi!**

"Great!", "Incredible!"

Very popular amongst girls and greatly overused.

可愛い! **Kawaii!**

"How cute!"

See *sugoi*.

えええ~ **Eee~**

"Reallyyyyyyy~?"

Almost a standard reaction to any kind of news. Can be lengthened indefinitely and is hence useful to stall for time when thinking about a real answer.

ウソ! **Uso!**

"Lie!"

Doesn't necessarily accuse one of lying, usually used in the sense of "Seriously?!"

Honorifics

Japanese makes extensive use of honorific language (敬語 *keigo*) when talking to people of higher status. Keigo is famously difficult to master and even Japanese salespeople often need to take special courses to learn to speak correctly. As a foreigner, you will generally not be expected to use keigo, but it is very commonly used in situations like salespeople talking to customers and public announcements, so having at least passive familiarity with the most common *keigo* verbs and constructs will come in very useful.

Respectful form

When talking to someone of higher status than yourself, it is important to use a respectful form (尊敬語 *sonkeigo*) when talking about the other

person. Generally, this follows the pattern お～になる(*o ~ ni naru*), where ~ represents the stem of the basic polite form: eg. to read, 読む (*yomu*), basic polite form 読みます(*yomimasu*) becomes お読みになる(*o-yomi-ni-naru*). The *naru* at the end follows the normal conjugation patterns for *naru*, most commonly becoming *narimasu* (present) or *narimashita* (past). The main exceptions are listed below:

- To see: 見る becomes ご覧になる (*goran-ni-naru*).
- To eat/drink: 食べる/飲む becomes 召し上がる (*meshi-agaru*).
- To come/go/be at a place: 来る/行く/いる becomes いらっしゃる (*irassharu*). (basic polite form いらっしゃいます *irasshaimasu* and **not** いらっしゃります)
- To know: 知る becomes ご存知だ (*gozonji-da*).
- To give (to yourself): くれる becomes 下さる (*kudasaru*). (basic polite form 下さいます *kudasaimasu* and **not** 下さります)
- To do: する becomes なさる (*nasaru*). (basic polite form なさいます *nasaimasu* and **not** なさります)
- To say: 言う becomes おっしゃる (*ossharu*) (basic polite form おっしゃいます *osshaimasu* and **not** おっしゃります)

Humble form

When talking about yourself to someone of higher status than you, it is important to put yourself down by using a humble form (謙遜語 *kensongo*). Generally this follows the pattern お～する (*o ~ suru*), where ~ represents the stem of the basic polite form: eg. to borrow, 借りる (*kariru*), basic polite form 借ります (*karimasu*) becomes お借りする (*o-kari-suru*). The *suru* at the end follows the usual conjugation pattern of *suru*, most commonly becoming *shimasu* (present) or *shimashita* (past); for an extra helping of humility, the verb 致す *itasu* > 致します *itashimasu* can be substituted. The main exceptions are listed below:

- To see: 見る becomes 拝見する (*haiken-suru*).
- To come/go: 来る/行く becomes 参る (*mairu*).
- To eat/drink/receive: 食べる/飲む/もらう becomes いただく (*itadaku*)
- To give: あげる becomes さし上げる (*sashi-ageru*).
- To do: する becomes 致す (*itasu*)
- To know: 知る becomes 存じる (*zonjiru*)

- To say: 言う becomes 申し上げる (*mōshi-ageru*)
- My name is: いう becomes 申す (*mōsu*)

Polite form

The third type of keigo is called simply "polite language", or *teineigo* (丁寧語). Whereas respectful and humble language refer to the *subject* (you and I), *teineigo* is used to simply imply respect to the *listener*. An example:

りんごをご覧になりますか? ***Ringo wo goran ni narimasuka?***

Can **you see** the apple? (*respectful*)

りんごを拝見します。 ***Ringo wo haiken shimasu.***

I **see** the apple. (*humble*)

彼もりんごを見ます。 ***Kare mo ringo wo mimasu.***

He also sees the apple. (*polite*)

In fact, the *desu* copula and the *-masu* form taught to beginning students of Japanese are both examples of *teineigo*. A few verbs and adjectives have special *teineigo* forms:

to be

aru (ある) → *gozaimasu* (ございます)

to die

shinu (死ぬ) → *nakunaru* (亡くなる)

good

ii/yoi (いい/良い) → *yoroshii* (よろしい)

Country and territory names

Country and territory names in Japanese are generally borrowed from their English names and written in katakana. The names of languages are generally formed by adding 語 (*go*) to the end of the country name. Only exceptions are mentioned below. Also one-kanji abbreviation for the country name is shown in 「 」:

アジア ***Ajia***

Asia 「亜」

日本 ***Nihon/Nippon***, 日本国 ***Nihon-koku***

Japan 「日」

中国 ***Chūgoku***

China (or, confusingly, Western Honshu) 「中」

台湾 ***Taiwan***

Taiwan 「台」

香港 **Honkon**

Hong Kong 「港」 (rare)

韓国 **Kankoku**

South Korea 「韓」

北朝鮮 **Kitachōsen**

North Korea 「朝」

インド **Indo**

India (not an abbreviation of Indonesia) 「印」

インドネシア **Indoneshia**

Indonesia

タイ **Tai**

Thailand 「泰」 (rare)

トルコ **Toruko**

Turkey 「土」

アラブ首長国連邦 **Arabu-shuchōkoku-rempō**

United Arab Emirates

イスラエル **Isuraeru**

Israel

ヨーロッパ **Yōroppa**

Europe 「欧」

ドイツ **Doitsu** (derived from 'Deutsche')

Germany 「独」

イギリス **Igirisu** (derived from 'English'), 英国 **Eikoku** (written)

United Kingdom 「英」

フランス **Furansu**

France 「仏」

イタリア **Itaria**

Italy 「伊」

スペイン **Supein**

Spain 「西」

オランダ **Oranda** (derived from 'Holland')

The Netherlands 「蘭」

ベルギー **Berugī**

Belgium 「白」 (rare)

ハンガリー *Hangarī*

Hungary 「洪」 (rare)

ロシア *Roshia*

Russia 「露」

アメリカ *Amerika*, 米国 *Beikoku* (written)

United States of America (not the whole American continent) 「米」

アフリカ *Afurika*

Africa

エジプト *Ejiputo*

Egypt

南アフリカ *Minami-afurika*

South Africa

エチオピア *Echiopia*

Ethiopia

オーストラリア *Ōsutoraria*, 豪州 *Gōshū*

Australia 「豪」

フィリピン *Fliripin*

Philippines